

The Resume Architecture Playbook

A practical checklist for engineering, data, product and SaaS roles

Build a resume that is easy to parse, fast to scan and difficult to forget.

The standard: Your resume is not a biography and it is not a keyword container. It is a targeted evidence document. Every line should help a recruiter answer: *Can this person do the work, at the level and scale we need?*

Start here: define the job before editing the resume

Target role	_____
Target level	☐ Intern ☐ New grad ☐ Mid-level ☐ Senior+
Top 5 requirements	_____
Three proof points	_____
Primary resume version	_____

The 30-second triage

- ☐ Can a reader identify your target function and strongest evidence in the top third?
- ☐ Are the most relevant experiences and projects easy to find without hunting?
- ☐ Does each important claim have proof: outcome, scale, complexity, ownership or adoption?
- ☐ Is the document written for this vacancy rather than for every possible job?
- ☐ Can the text be selected and copied cleanly from the exported PDF?

Length is a judgment, not a ritual. One page is a strong default for students and early-career candidates. Use a second page when relevant evidence genuinely improves the hiring decision. Never shrink type, crush spacing or delete your best proof merely to obey a slogan.

Your evidence score

Score each dimension from 0 to 2: **0** missing, **1** present but weak, **2** clear and convincing.

Dimension	/2	Dimension	/2
Target-role alignment		Outcomes and impact	
Relevant technical depth		Ownership and decisions	
Readable structure		ATS-safe extraction	
Credibility and consistency		Links and portfolio proof	
		Total	/16

Interpretation: 13–16 = ready to tailor; 9–12 = focused revision; 0–8 = rebuild the evidence architecture before polishing.

1. Choose the right architecture

Section order should follow relevance, not tradition.

Student / new grad	Header → Education or Skills → Experience → Projects → Leadership / Awards
Experienced hire	Header → Summary (only if useful) → Experience → Skills → Projects / Education
Career transition	Header → Targeted Summary → Transferable Skills → Relevant Experience / Projects → Earlier Experience → Education
Research-heavy	Header → Research Focus → Education → Research Experience → Publications / Presentations → Skills

Structure and visual integrity

- ☐ Use a single-column reading order for the safest parsing and fastest scanning.
- ☐ Use familiar headings: Experience, Education, Projects, Skills, Publications.
- ☐ Keep body text around 10–12 pt, with comfortable line spacing and visible section separation.
- ☐ Keep dates, locations, capitalization, punctuation and verb tense consistent.
- ☐ Use bold selectively to create scan paths; avoid underlining ordinary text.
- ☐ Avoid headshots, skill bars, ratings, charts and decorative icons in the ATS version.
- ☐ Export a text-based PDF unless the application explicitly requests another format.
- ☐ Use a professional filename: `FirstName_LastName_TargetRole.pdf`.

ATS-safe does not mean lifeless

The goal is reliable text extraction, not gaming an imaginary universal score. ATS products differ. Use clean hierarchy, standard labels and truthful role-relevant language. Do not hide keywords, paste the job description into the file, or repeat terms unnaturally.

- ☐ Include exact tools or competencies from the job description only when you can defend them.
- ☐ Prefer natural variants where accurate: “CI/CD pipelines” and “continuous integration.”
- ☐ Keep critical contact information in the main document body; parsers may treat headers differently.
- ☐ Test extraction: copy all PDF text into a plain-text editor and verify reading order.
- ☐ Check file size and upload behavior in the employer portal before the deadline.

2. Header, summary and skills

Header

- ☐ Include name, city/country, professional email, phone, LinkedIn and a relevant portfolio/GitHub.
- ☐ Remove age, date of birth, marital status, religion, full street address and photo unless local norms or the role explicitly require them.
- ☐ Replace long raw URLs with short, descriptive links and test every destination while logged out.

Summary: earn the space

Use a 2–3 line summary when it clarifies a transition, specialization or senior value proposition. Skip generic objectives.

Useful pattern: [Role/specialization] with [relevant scope] who has delivered [credible proof]. Strong in [2–3 target capabilities], now targeting [specific problem/role].

Skills

- ☐ Group concrete skills: Languages, Frameworks, Data, Cloud/DevOps, Tools, Methods.
- ☐ Prioritize skills relevant to the vacancy; remove obsolete, trivial or undefendable items.
- ☐ Do not rate yourself with stars or percentages. Demonstrate proficiency through experience.
- ☐ Show soft skills through actions and outcomes rather than a standalone adjective list.

3. Engineer bullets that carry evidence

Strong bullets communicate contribution, method and significance.

Evidence formula Action + object/problem + method/constraints + result/learning

Example Reduced API p95 latency from 480 ms to 190 ms by profiling N+1 queries and adding indexed batch reads, improving checkout completion during peak traffic.

Experience checklist

- ☐ Use reverse chronology and clearly identify organization, title, location and dates.
- ☐ Lead with the result or most important contribution; do not copy the job description.
- ☐ State your ownership: designed, implemented, led, analyzed, migrated, automated, validated.
- ☐ Add metrics when they are meaningful and defensible—not to satisfy an arbitrary quota.
- ☐ When revenue metrics are unavailable, use scale proxies: users, requests, records, latency, accuracy, cycle time, failure rate, coverage, cost, adoption or team scope.
- ☐ Explain collaboration only when it reveals your contribution or decision-making.
- ☐ Use present tense for ongoing work and past tense for completed work.
- ☐ Keep the most important bullets first; remove routine responsibilities that add no signal.

Bullet quality test

For every bullet, underline the **action**, circle the **technical or business context**, and box the **proof**. If one component is absent, decide whether to revise or delete.

Weak	Responsible for building dashboards for sales.
Better	Built five Power BI dashboards integrating CRM and billing data, cutting weekly reporting preparation from four hours to 35 minutes for 18 sales managers.
Weak	Worked on a web application using React.
Better	Implemented an accessible React onboarding flow with schema-based validation and event tracking; reduced incomplete registrations by 21% in an A/B test.

4. Projects that prove you can ship

Projects matter when they show decisions, constraints and completion—not merely a technology list.

- ☐ State the user/problem and what you personally built.
- ☐ Name the architecture or hard technical decision only when it adds signal.
- ☐ Show validation: users, tests, performance, deployment, dataset size, accuracy or feedback.
- ☐ Link to a live demo or focused repository with a clear README and setup instructions.
- ☐ Remove tutorial clones unless you extended them substantially and can explain the trade-offs.
- ☐ For team projects, separate your contribution from the team's overall result.
- ☐ Never expose API keys, personal data, proprietary code or broken deployments.

Repository pre-flight: descriptive README ☐ architecture/context ☐ working setup ☐ tests ☐
screenshots/demo ☐ sensible commit history ☐

5. Education, certifications and additional evidence

- ☐ Include degree, institution, location and expected/completed date.
- ☐ Add GPA only when it strengthens the application or is requested; use the correct scale.
- ☐ Include relevant coursework sparingly when you lack stronger evidence.
- ☐ List certifications with issuer and date; prioritize current, role-relevant credentials.
- ☐ Include awards, leadership, open source, publications or volunteering when they demonstrate relevant capabilities.
- ☐ Do not include references or “references available upon request” unless requested.

6. Tailor without fabricating

1. Highlight the role’s recurring problems, required capabilities and level signals.
2. Map each priority to evidence you genuinely possess.
3. Reorder sections and bullets so the strongest matches appear early.
4. Use the employer’s terminology where it accurately describes your work.
5. Close gaps with context or a relevant project—never invented experience.

Match matrix
Role requirement

My evidence

Resume location

7. Use AI as an editor, not an author of fake evidence

First create your own factual inventory. Do not upload confidential employer data, private customer information or secrets.

Prompt 1: evidence interview

“I am targeting [role]. Interview me about this experience: [draft]. Ask one question at a time about the problem, my decisions, tools, scale, constraints, collaborators and measurable result. Do not invent facts. After my answers, propose three concise bullets and mark every assumption.”

Prompt 2: ruthless relevance review

“Act as a technical recruiter for [job description]. Evaluate my resume only against the evidence on the page. Identify: (1) unclear target, (2) unsupported claims, (3) buried proof, (4) irrelevant content, (5) missing but truthful keywords. Rank revisions by interview impact. Do not reward keyword stuffing.”

Prompt 3: bullet stress test

“For each bullet, label Action, Context, Method and Result. Flag vague verbs, unverifiable metrics and missing ownership. Suggest a tighter rewrite using only the facts I supplied. If evidence is missing, ask a question instead of filling the gap.”

Prompt 4: human-sounding final pass

“Edit for clarity, specificity and natural professional English. Preserve facts, technical meaning and my voice. Remove inflated adjectives, repetitive sentence patterns and generic AI phrasing. Return a change log explaining every material edit.”

8. Integrity and risk checks

- ☐ Every metric, title, date, tool and claim can be explained in an interview.
- ☐ No confidential, security-sensitive or personally identifying third-party data appears.
- ☐ AI-generated text has been fact-checked and rewritten in your own voice.
- ☐ Employment gaps and overlapping dates are accurate and consistently represented.

The 10-minute application pre-flight

Content: 4 minutes

- ☐ The target role is obvious in the first third of the page.
- ☐ The strongest, most relevant evidence appears before secondary material.
- ☐ Bullets show contribution and proof; vague responsibility statements are gone.
- ☐ Keywords are truthful, contextual and aligned with the job description.
- ☐ Spelling, tense, punctuation and dates are consistent.

Parsing and layout: 3 minutes

- ☐ PDF text selects, copies and pastes in the intended reading order.
- ☐ No clipped lines, orphan headings, tiny type, dense blocks or broken characters.
- ☐ Contact information and links are visible, correct and clickable.
- ☐ The file opens correctly on desktop and mobile and meets portal size/type limits.

Credibility: 2 minutes

- ☐ Portfolio, GitHub and LinkedIn tell a consistent story.
- ☐ All claims are defensible; no fabricated tools, metrics or responsibilities.
- ☐ Public repositories and linked demos work in a logged-out browser.

Submission: 1 minute

- ☐ Filename is professional and role-specific.
- ☐ Correct resume version is attached; form fields match the resume.
- ☐ A final copy of the job description and submitted resume is saved for interview prep.

Ready means relevant, readable and real.

A scanner may parse the document. A human still decides whether the evidence deserves a conversation.